

Credit - Drishti Ias

Three-Language Formula and Nagaland's Linguistic Challenge



Source: TH

Why in News?

The Association of Unaided CBSE Schools in Nagaland has expressed concerns over the **Central Board of Secondary Education's (CBSE)** mandate to implement the **Three-Language Formula under National Education Policy (NEP) 2020**. The association has termed the **policy "not viable" for the state** due to its unique linguistic demographic and severe resource constraints.

- Nagaland has **no single common regional language, with 17 major tribes speaking distinct languages**. English serves as the official language and medium of instruction, while none of the state's tribal languages is included in the **Eighth Schedule**.
- Additionally, a lack of trained teachers, textbooks, and standardized curricula makes implementation difficult, especially in linguistically diverse classrooms.

What is the Three-Language Formula?

- **Background:** The Three-Language Formula was first formulated by the Ministry of Education in 1968 based on the recommendations of the **Kothari Commission (1964-66)**.
 - **NEP, 1968** emphasised study of **Hindi, English and a modern Indian language** (preferably one of the southern languages) in Hindi-speaking States and **Hindi, English and a regional language in non-Hindi speaking States**.
- **Three-Language Formula under NEP 2020:** The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 requires students to learn three languages. This policy is designed to promote multilingualism while respecting India's cultural and regional diversity.
 - **Native Indian Languages:** At least two of the three chosen languages must be native Indian languages.
 - **Flexibility and Autonomy:** Unlike the NEP of 1968, which rigidly mandated Hindi, English, and a regional language, the NEP 2020 allows for **flexibility in language selection. States, regions, and students have the autonomy to choose the languages they wish to study**.
 - **Foreign Languages:** A foreign language can only be taken as the third language (R3) if the other two are native Indian languages. Alternatively, a foreign language can be taken as an optional fourth language.

- **CBSE Mandate:** Under the **National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE)**, CBSE proposed that **students study three languages up to Class 10**, with at least two being native Indian languages.
- **Teacher Accommodations:** Schools facing shortages of qualified native language teachers can use existing staff who have "functional proficiency" in the language as an interim measure.
 - Schools are encouraged to use flexible solutions like **inter-school sharing (Sahodaya clusters)**, hybrid/virtual teaching, or hiring retired teachers.

Evolution of the Three-Language Formula Policy

- **Kothari Commission (1964-66):** First proposed the three-language formula to balance national integration with regional identities.
- **National Policy on Education, 1968:** Officially adopted the formula, advocating the use of regional languages at primary and secondary stages, and calling for their adoption at the university level.
- **Programme of Action, 1992:** Emphasized that the mother tongue or regional language should be the medium of communication at the pre-school level.
- **Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009:** Mandated that, as far as practicable, the medium of instruction in schools should be the child's mother tongue.
- **National Education Policy (NEP), 2020:** Advocates utilizing the home language, mother tongue, local language, or regional language as the medium of instruction.

Constitutional Provisions Related to Language

- **Article 29:** Protects the interests of minorities, ensuring that any section of citizens with a distinct language, script, or culture has the right to conserve the same.
- **Article 343:** Declares Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union; allows continued use of English for official purposes for 15 years from 1950 (later extended by legislation).
- **Article 345:** Empowers the state legislature to adopt any one or more of the languages in use in the state or Hindi as the official language of that state.
- **Article 346:** Governs the official language for communication between states and with the Union. Hindi may be used if the states involved agree.
- **Article 347:** Allows the President to recognize a language as an official language of a state or part thereof, if a substantial section of the population demands it.
- **Article 350A:** Directs every state and local authority to provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education to children belonging to linguistic minority groups.
- **Article 351 of the Constitution:** Makes it a duty of the Union to promote the spread and development of the Hindi language.
- **Eighth Schedule:** Lists the official languages of the Republic of India (currently 22 languages).



THE THREE-LANGUAGE FORMULA

BENEFITS AND CHALLENGES



The Three-Language Formula under NEP 2020 promotes multilingualism and respects India's linguistic diversity. Here are its key advantages and the arguments against it.



ADVANTAGES OF THE THREE-LANGUAGE FORMULA



ACCESS & INCLUSION

1. ENHANCES ACCESS AND INCLUSION

- **Wider Access:** Helps children from diverse linguistic backgrounds learn in a language they comprehend.
- **Parental Engagement:** Learning in native languages boosts parental involvement.
- **Inclusivity:** Respects and integrates the linguistic and cultural diversity of marginalized groups.



BETTER LEARNING OUTCOMES

2. IMPROVES LEARNING OUTCOMES

- **Socio-emotional Growth:** Helps children express themselves better and understand diverse perspectives.
- **Academic Performance:** Research shows multilingual students often excel in other subjects due to enhanced cognitive abilities.



SUPPORTS SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

3. SUPPORTS SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

- **Cultural Preservation:** Protects indigenous languages and traditions for future generations.
- **Economic Benefits:** Multilingualism drives economic growth (e.g., Switzerland attributes 10% of its GDP to its multilingual heritage).
- **Environmental Protection:** Indigenous languages preserve traditional ecological knowledge.



FACILITATES NATIONAL INTEGRATION

4. FACILITATES NATIONAL INTEGRATION

- Promotes effective cross-regional communication and fosters "Unity in Diversity" by building respect for different cultures.



MULTILINGUALISM TODAY, STRONGER INDIA TOMORROW.

“The Three-Language Formula, if implemented with flexibility, resources, and sensitivity to regional realities, can be a powerful tool for inclusive education and national unity.”



ARGUMENTS AGAINST THE THREE-LANGUAGE FORMULA



1. CHALLENGES FOR LINGUISTICALLY DIVERSE STATES

- States like Nagaland, with multiple tribal languages and limited resources, struggle to implement the formula.
- Developing standardized curricula for many local languages is administratively difficult.



2. EXECUTION DIFFICULTIES

- Past attempts have faced practical hurdles. For instance, Haryana previously introduced Tamil as a language option but faced immense difficulties in execution.



3. SHORTAGE OF QUALIFIED TEACHERS

- There is a severe shortage of qualified teachers for second and third languages.
- Hiring them diverts crucial funds from basic infrastructure and faculty training.



4. STRUGGLES IN PRIMARY EDUCATION

- Many students already lack foundational literacy.
- Adding a compulsory third language could overburden the system and cause confusion for children from monolingual homes.



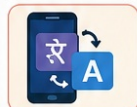
5. POLITICISATION AND 'SONS OF THE SOIL'

- Language is politically sensitive. Policies may be viewed with suspicion or used to mobilize regional chauvinism, threatening migrants and potentially hampering national integrity.



6. LANGUAGE AS A CHOICE, NOT COMPULSION

- Critics argue that language learning should be driven by individual or professional needs later in life, not by compulsory school policies.



7. TECHNOLOGICAL ALTERNATIVES

- Rapid advancement of AI translation tools (like Google Gemini) reduces the functional barrier of language, making forced multilingual proficiency less critical for basic communication.



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Three-Language Formula under NEP 2020?

It requires students to learn **three languages**, with **at least two being native Indian languages**, while allowing flexibility to states and students in language selection.

2. Which commission first recommended the Three-Language Formula?

The **Kothari Commission (1964-66)** first proposed the formula to promote national integration while respecting regional linguistic identities.

3. What does Article 350A of the Constitution provide?

Article 350A directs states to provide adequate facilities for **mother-tongue instruction at the primary stage** for children belonging to linguistic minority groups.

4. Why has Nagaland opposed the CBSE language mandate?

Nagaland lacks a single common regional language, has **17 major tribal languages**, and faces shortages of teachers, textbooks, and standardized curricula for multilingual implementation.

5. What is the significance of the Eighth Schedule in language policy?

The **Eighth Schedule** recognizes **22 official languages** of India and serves as an important reference for language promotion, education, and cultural preservation.

6. What does Article 351 mandate?

Article 351 directs the Union to promote the spread and development of **Hindi** while drawing upon elements from other Indian languages to enrich it.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/cTmkvP89-mA](https://www.youtube.com/embed/cTmkvP89-mA)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. Which of the following provisions of the Constitution does India have a bearing on Education? (2012)

1. Directive Principles of State Policy
2. Rural and Urban Local Bodies
3. Fifth Schedule
4. Sixth Schedule
5. Seventh Schedule

Select the correct answer using the codes given below:

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3, 4 and 5 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 5 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3, 4 and 5

Ans: (d)

Mains

Q. Discuss the main objectives of Population Education and point out the measures to achieve them in India in detail. (2021)

Q. How have digital initiatives in India contributed to the functioning of the education system in the country? Elaborate on your answer. (2020)

Challenges of Journalism in India



For Prelims: Misinformation , Article 19 , Telecom Regulatory Authority of India , Press Council of India , World Press Freedom Index

For Mains: Role of media in strengthening democratic governance, Impact of social media on public discourse and democratic institutions, Fake news, misinformation, and challenges to national security.

Why in News?

Amid growing concerns over **misinformation** on **social media** , controversies surrounding the **NEET 2026 paper leak**, and the misuse of **digital platforms** , the debate on the credibility and **sustainability of Mainstream Media (MSM)** has resurfaced.

- Experts argue that a strong, independent, and subscription-supported media ecosystem is essential for safeguarding informed public discourse and democratic governance.

Summary

- Social media has transformed information sharing by enabling citizen participation and rapid communication, but it has also accelerated misinformation, fake news, echo chambers, and societal polarization through algorithm-driven content amplification.
- Mainstream Media faces challenges from the attention economy, corporate influence, regulatory weaknesses, and political pressures, making reforms such as algorithmic transparency, media literacy, stronger press institutions, anti-SLAPP laws, and subscriber-funded journalism essential for protecting democracy.

How has Social Media Disrupted the Flow of Information?

- **Shift to Horizontal Information Flow:** Social media has transformed information dissemination from a **vertical model** (authority to masses through MSM) to a **horizontal model** (peer-to-peer sharing).
- **Democratization vs. Anarchy:** While **Social media has democratized information and empowered citizens** to hold authorities accountable (as seen when affected students clearly explained the NEET/CBSE issues online), it has simultaneously **created "information anarchy."**
 - Misinformation can lead to violence and unrest, threatening social stability. In **2018, WhatsApp rumors** about child kidnappers in India led to mob lynchings across several states, causing deaths and public disorder.
- **Rapid Spread of Misinformation:** Alongside genuine grievances, vast amounts of **unverified information and rumors circulate on Social media** , generating widespread public panic and social and political chaos.
 - Fake news can **manipulate public opinion, especially during elections, undermining the democratic process.**
 - Fake news undermines **citizens' right to information** , which is protected **under Article 19 as upheld by the Supreme Court of India in Raj Narayan vs. Uttar Pradesh Government (1975).**
- **Rise of Algorithmic Amplification:** Social media platforms use **AI-driven algorithms** to personalize content based on user behavior such as watch time and scrolling patterns.
 - These algorithms prioritize engagement, showing users content that aligns with their existing preferences and beliefs.
 - This creates **echo chambers (environments where people are exposed mainly to similar opinions)** and **filter bubbles (algorithm-driven information silos that limit diverse**

viewpoints) , increasing societal polarization.

What is the Current Crisis Facing Mainstream Media (MSM)?

Technological and Economic Subversion

- **The "Attention Economy":** In a bid to beat social media algorithms, MSM platforms and journalists have abandoned their traditional role as independent mediators of information.
 - MSM increasingly prioritizes clickbait, short-form content, and sensational debates over substantive reporting. The growing "**Murdochization**" of media, marked by **concentrated ownership and profit-driven journalism** , has further amplified this trend, with studio theatrics often replacing ground reporting and distancing news coverage from real public concerns.
- **Ethical Implication:** As the **fourth pillar of democracy, the media's traditional role is to act as an independent mediator of information**. However, many mainstream platforms have abandoned this responsibility. This represents a breach of **professional integrity** .
 - By prioritizing sensationalism (**Yellow Journalism**) , media houses compromise their deontological duty to educate and inform the public, exploiting human prejudice for profit.
 - The **Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP)** encourage scientific temper, rational thinking, and inquiry, yet some prime-time **television content promotes superstition, pseudo-science, and unverified claims**, potentially weakening critical thinking among viewers.

Corporate Monopolization and 'Lawfare'

- **Conflict of Interest:** Corporate conglomerates acquiring major news networks institutionalizes self-censorship, actively suppressing **reportage detrimental to the parent company's commercial interests**.
- **Weaponization of SLAPPs:** Corporate entities routinely deploy **Strategic Lawsuits Against Public Participation (SLAPP)** to financially exhaust and deter investigative journalists.
- **Regulatory Vacuum:** Despite repeated **Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI)** warnings against market monopolization, **India lacks statutory firewalls to regulate cross-media holdings**.
 - In **Secretary, Ministry of I&B vs. CAB (1995)** , the Supreme Court declared airwaves as "*public property*" that must be used to promote a plurality of opinions, **obligating the state to prevent their monopolization by corporate entities**.

State Coercion and Executive Overreach

- **Statutory Weaponization:** In **Madhyamam Broadcasting Ltd. vs. Union of India (2023)** , the Supreme Court struck down the **arbitrary use of "national security" paradigms** and sealed-cover jurisprudence to revoke broadcast licenses, **shielding the press from executive "chilling effects."**
 - However, there is a discernible trend of deploying stringent penal provisions, including the **Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act 1967** , **Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA)** , and criminal defamation, as tools of 'lawfare' against dissenting journalists.
- **Advertising Leverage:** State and Union governments frequently use the allocation or withdrawal of **Directorate of Advertising and Visual Publicity (DAVP) funds** to engineer editorial compliance.
 - In **Bennett Coleman & Co. vs. Union of India (1972)**, the Supreme Court ruled that policies causing financial strangulation or limiting the economic viability of the press directly violate **Article**

Institutional and Regulatory Deficits

- **The Toothless Watchdog:** Established under the **Press Council Act, 1978** , the **Press Council of India (PCI)** is a statutory, quasi-judicial body that safeguards press standards.
 - Its effectiveness is limited as it lacks **punitive enforcement powers** and has jurisdiction only over **print media** .
 - PCI cannot regulate **electronic broadcasting, digital news platforms** , or effectively curb practices such as **paid news** .
- **IT Rules 2021 Friction:** The **Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021** , introduced a self-regulatory mechanism overseen by an **inter-departmental government committee**.
 - This has triggered constitutional friction regarding **executive intrusion into digital editorial spaces, raising concerns under Article 19(1)(a)**.
 - In the landmark **Shreya Singhal vs. Union of India (2015)** judgment, the Supreme Court struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, 2000. The Court ruled that **overbroad and vague laws cause a severe "chilling effect" on legitimate digital free speech and self-censorship**.
- **Security Threats:** Rampant violence, intimidation, and attacks on journalists continue to undermine press freedom in India.
 - Reflecting these challenges, India was ranked 157th out of 180 countries in the **2026 World Press Freedom Index** published by Reporters Without Borders.

The Societal and Democratic Cost

- **The "Free Rubbish" Paradox:** The public criticizes MSM's declining standards yet blindly **consumes unverified, often dangerous, free information** (e.g., fake medical fixes) from anonymous social media sources.
- **Democratic Deficit:** As traditional reporting weakens and governments actively bypass **media scrutiny, the lack of trusted communication channels creates a void in accountability and threatens social stability**.

What Measures are Needed to Restore Democratic Journalism?

- **Curb Fake News:** The **Parliamentary Standing Committee on Communications and Information Technology (2025)** has recommended a **multi-pronged approach** to curb fake news, including fact-checking mechanisms and internal ombudsmen in media organizations, stricter penalties for misinformation, and a clear legal definition of "fake news" while safeguarding freedom of speech.
 - It also recommended strengthening the **Press Council of India (PCI)** through a complaint portal and independent monitoring body, along with mandatory labeling and regulation of AI-generated content to improve transparency and curb deceptive material.
- **Adopt Subscriber-Funded Models:** Shift to a **"user-pays" system** . Citizens must **pay for news directly to sever media reliance** on corporate and political funding, eliminate the need for clickbait, and guarantee editorial independence.
- **Revive Beat Reporting:** Restore dedicated beat reporters to ensure clear, transparent communication

between authorities and the public regarding government policies.

- **Enact Anti-SLAPP Laws:** Pass legislation to protect investigative journalists from malicious lawsuits designed by corporations or organized crime to silence them.
- **Protect Constitutional Freedoms:** Uphold the constitutional right to free speech (Article 19(1)(a)).
 - The state must stop weaponizing anti-terror laws to **penalize journalists for administrative criticism**.
- **Enforce Algorithmic Transparency:** Mandate that social media and search algorithms prioritize verified, factual reporting over sensationalism, removing the financial incentives for outrage-driven clickbait.
- **Mandate Media Literacy:** Integrate rigorous media literacy programs into education systems to equip citizens with the tools to critically evaluate sources, identify misinformation, and actively seek out credible news.
- **International Best Practices for Media Regulation:** India can learn from global models to make media regulation more effective. **Australia's News Media Bargaining Code** requires big tech companies like Google and Meta to pay news publishers for using their content, helping independent media remain financially sustainable.
 - Similarly, the **European Union's Digital Services Act (DSA)** makes large online platforms accountable for tackling fake news, hate speech, and election manipulation by ensuring greater transparency in how their algorithms operate.

Conclusion

As former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee profoundly remarked, "***The press is either free, or it cannot be called the press at all.***"

In the modern digital landscape, to remain democratically liberated from corporate and state hegemony, journalism can no longer be financially free to the consumer. **Treating information as a costless commodity degrades the media into an algorithmic race** fueled by algorithmically driven sensationalism rather than verified facts. Ultimately, if citizens refuse to financially invest in independent news, **society will inevitably pay the democratic price for this noise.**

Drishti Mains Question:

Social media has democratized information but also intensified misinformation and polarization. Critically examine.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Press Council of India (PCI)?

PCI is a statutory, quasi-judicial body established under the **Press Council Act, 1978** to maintain journalistic standards and protect press freedom, though it lacks punitive powers and mainly covers print media.

2. What are Echo Chambers and Filter Bubbles?

Echo chambers expose users mainly to similar viewpoints, while **filter bubbles** are algorithm-driven information silos that limit diverse perspectives, increasing societal polarization.

3. What was the significance of the Shreya Singhal v. Union of India (2015) judgment?

The Supreme Court struck down **Section 66A of the IT Act, 2000**, holding that vague restrictions on online speech create a chilling effect on free expression protected under **Article 19(1)(a)**.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/FVEIMECP4p4](https://www.youtube.com/embed/FVEIMECP4p4)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Mains

Q. What do you understand by the concept of “freedom of speech and expression”? Does it cover hate speech also? Why do the films in India stand on a slightly different plane from other forms of expression? Discuss. **(2014)**

India on Track to Achieve 3% Compressed Biogas Blending Target



Source: TH

India is steadily progressing towards its target of blending **3% Compressed Biogas (CBG)** with **Compressed Natural Gas (CNG)** and domestic **Piped Natural Gas (PNG)** in the current financial year, as the existing blending level has already reached nearly **2%**, indicating consistent advancement under the **National Biofuel Policy framework**.

- **NBCC Blending Roadmap:** As per the **National Biofuel Coordination Committee (NBCC)** roadmap, India aims for **1% CBG blending in 2025-26**, rising progressively to **3% in 2026-27**, and further to **4-5% in subsequent years**, indicating a long-term clean energy transition strategy.

- **CBG Infrastructure Expansion:** According to the Petroleum Ministry’s [Gobardhan portal](#) , 210 CBG/bio-CNG plants have been commissioned so far. Among the plants currently under construction, the highest number are in **U ttar Pradesh (80), Maharashtra (46), Gujarat (35), and Karnataka (25)** .
- **Significance and Challenges:** CBG blending can strengthen India’s **energy security, reduce fuel imports, promote waste utilisation, reduce methane emissions, and help prevent crop residue burning** . However, experts stress the need for assured feedstock supply and production-linked incentives to support CBG expansion.

Compressed Biogas (CBG)

- **Compressed Biogas (CBG):** It is a **renewable fuel** produced from biomass and organic waste (agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugarcane press mud, sewage) via **anaerobic decomposition** (breakdown of organic matter by bacteria in the absence of oxygen).
- **Properties:** Similar **calorific value** (amount of energy released on complete combustion) to CNG. CBG can replace CNG in **automotive, industrial, and commercial sectors** .

Feature	CBG (Compressed Biogas)	CNG (Compressed Natural Gas)
Source	Produced from biomass and organic waste .	Extracted from fossil fuels (natural gas fields)
Environmental Impact	Eco-friendly , reduces air pollution (e.g., stubble burning), utilizes waste, supports circular economy	Cleaner than petrol/diesel but fossil fuel-based , contributes to greenhouse gas emissions if not captured efficiently.
Dependence on Imports	Can be produced domestically from local biomass , reducing import dependence	Import dependency in the case of natural gas was at 50.8% in FY25, increasing foreign dependence
Commercial Viability	Supports rural employment and renewable energy initiatives	Conventional energy source, limited scope for rural livelihood creation

Read More: [India’s First Cooperative Compressed Biogas Plant](#)

World Refugee Day



Source: TH

World Refugee Day , observed annually on **20th June** , is a [United Nations](#) -designated international day to honour refugees forced to flee conflict or persecution.

- **Theme 2026:** The theme **“Until Everyone Is Safe”** highlights the idea that protection must be universal and should not depend on nationality, wealth, race, religion, gender, political opinion or migration status.
- **Background:** It was first celebrated on **20th June 2001** to commemorate the **50th anniversary of the 1951 Convention** Relating to the Status of Refugees.
- **1951 Refugee Convention and 1967 Protocol:** These are the key global legal instruments that protect refugees, ensuring they receive at least the same treatment as other foreign nationals and, in many cases, treatment similar to nationals of the host country.
 - The Convention defines not only the rights of refugees but also their obligations towards the host country, establishing a **balanced legal framework** for protection and responsibility.
- **Principle of Non-Refoulement:** The 1951 Convention prohibits returning refugees to a country where they face threats to life or freedom, except in cases where they pose a serious security risk or have committed a particularly serious crime.
- **Refugees:** A refugee is a person who "owing to well-founded fear of being persecuted for reasons of race, religion, nationality, membership of a particular social group or political opinion, is outside the country of their nationality and is unable or, owing to such fear, is unwilling to avail themselves of the protection of that country."
- **Types of Forcibly Displaced Persons:** The displaced population includes **refugees** (crossing borders due to fear of persecution), **asylum seekers** (whose claims are under examination), **internally displaced persons** (within their own country), **stateless persons** (without recognised nationality), and **returnees** (who return after exile).
- **Mandate:** According to the [United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees \(UNHCR\)](#) , there were about 41.6 million refugees globally at the end of December 2025, while around 6 million Palestine refugees are assisted by the **United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA)**.

Read More: [India's Path to Protecting Refugees](#)